Merry Christmas 2025
And some of 2026

Merry Christmas 2025!
It's amazing how fast a year goes by!
Packed with work, travel and family fun,
In the blink of an eye the year was done.

January brought skiing in Beaver Creek,
Then rehearsals for *Newsies* at least 4 times a week.
John drove to Atlanta to see ND play OSU
With cousin Jim, a Notre Dame grad, too.

(He'd prefer an ND win, but he couldn't lose —
Being a graduate of both ND and OSU.)

Lauren's Mike turned 30 on February 5
And his dad included us in a family surprise.
Mike's parents, brother and twin sisters, too,
All gathered in Boulder — that Lauren knew.
The surprise took place at a Japanese restaurant
Where Lauren took Mike "to pick up takeout."

A total success as Mike looked happily shocked!
Then Lauren saw us and suddenly stopped!
The weekend that followed was full of laughter, food and fun,
Exploring Boulder and getting to know everyone.

March brought *Newsies, Jr.* to the Hastings stage—
A fun show with great character roles to be played.
John had a meeting out in San Francisco
But made it home in time to see our final show.

Then off to Florida for our spring break trip
With as many of our kids and grandkids who could make it.
Another great time on Gasparilla Isle
Seeing Jan and Tom and my sister Kris for a little while.

We took the long route to drive to D.C,
Stopping first in Melbourne, Kris's new home to see.
On a canal, a lovely home in a beautiful spot!
We got to see David, Alex, & Lennon, as well as Kris and Scott.

We briefly saw sights in St. Augustine -
Were impressed by Flagler University -
Then back on the road for another day and a half.
I doubt we will ever again try to do that!

John's AAO advocacy meeting went well in D.C.
He is justifiably proud of his stellar mentees.
We stayed with Lisa's family and had some great fun,
Lots of activity and laughter before any day was done.

John, Elizabeth and Mateo came here for Easter week.
Mateo did great at Easter egg Hide-N-Seek!
He enjoyed a Zamboni ride before a CBJ game,
And at COSI taught Buddy every dinosaur's name.

We drove to Findlay to see *Come From Away*
With Susan and Chris, a spectacular play!
I highly recommend seeing it as often as you can.
It rebuilds your faith in the goodness of man!

Our whole family got together the first week of May
Back in Boulder, Colorado, to celebrate graduation days.
Elizabeth and John both walked for their PhD's
In their separate departments' ceremonies.

We picnicked at Chautauqua, the picture you see
Is from that occasion with the whole family.
Having four days together was quite the treat,
With all three generations—That's truly sweet!

June brought a brief visit from former roommate Georgeanne,
From Boise, Idaho, for a quick weekend planned
Around her niece's high school performance in Dayton nearby,
Filled with memories, laughter, fun, and how fast time flies!

It also brought the wedding of Katherine to nephew Ben,
A couple Lauren introduced to each other back when
They went over to swim in Ben's family pool.
(Lauren & Katherine have been friends since they started school*)

The whole family made it home for the wedding weekend,
Another great occasion to be together again!
The wedding was exquisitely beautiful, creative and fun!
A meaningful celebration for everyone.

In July, a friend's wedding brought Paul's family back.
They stayed at our house, and we babysat.
Had loads of fun with Gemma and Finn,
And slept really well after they were tucked in!

Celebrated Allison's birthday with dinner at Smith's
(Her mom can cook! Every dish was delish!)
Then we flew to DC for the end of birthday week,
Celebrating three Lowes gaining a year each.

Then to Wisconsin for niece Taylor's marriage to Ashe,
A joyous wedding and reception, both a blast!
Many meaningful details and well-chosen words,
The love in the room truly felt, not just heard.

School started, but soon after, John and I left
For Lisbon, over my birthday (a secret I thought I had kept)
But they check passports carefully at the hotel where we stayed,
And served me champagne and pasteis with candle aflame.

Lisbon was lovely: guides, food, sites, and history,
With a welcoming population full of positivity.
We left there for Porto and a Douro river cruise
With Jeri & Peter and three more couples, too.

The Douro valley is beautiful, our company fun,
Went through the tallest lock in Europe before the trip was done.
Then quickly home and off to Boulder for this year's wedding #3
Where niece Julia brought Greg into our family!

A captivating ceremony blessed by a few sprinkles of rain.
The sky then cleared completely before the dancing began.
Heartfelt toasts and speeches showed how these two are loved
Along with the gift of sparkling stars and clear skies above.

I came home to auditions for Hastings' fall one-act plays
And quickly got immersed in rehearsal days.
I chose a challenging script with 25 teens
All on stage with no break through the final scene.

That meant at rehearsals everyone was on stage
(I didn't have to police any actors who strayed.)
Actors had to maintain character for at least 40 minutes
A difficult challenge for everyone in it!

This worked because my cohort took a larger cast.
I'm forever thankful to David for taking on that task!
Each of the students' acting grew by leaps and bounds,
Their performances superb; the challenge proved sound.

Mike emailed our family and asked us to find
A date between October & December when we all had time
To meet in Boulder and surprise Lauren at a dinner
After he proposed to her—October 3rd was the winner

All four siblings and spouses, their children, John and I
Arranged to get to Boulder with Mike's parents in time
To be waiting at a favorite restaurant with a photographer, too,
Who captured Lauren's shocked joy as she entered the room!

Engaged at a picturesque mountain spot
Then surprised by all of us—that's quite a lot!
Followed by two days of Colorado fun
So much joy shared before the weekend was done!

Back home we celebrated with another ‘family’
My sisters from Kappa Psi sorority!
Who came to Columbus for a weekend of fun
Exploring, reminiscing and laughing a ton!

Such a great group of women (& spouses) all helping me see
The assets of our Columbus community!
Taking in sites, where we’d not normally be
When everyday life gets way too busy!

John traveled to Orlando for AAO
I stayed home to work on my fall show
A quick visit from Joe Burns, John’s roommate at ND,
Giving an OSU lecture on engineering that we got to see.

These events remind us how lucky we’ve been
To get to know so many talented friends,
With knowledge so detailed over topics widespread
Sharing fascinating info to store in our heads!

Our Thanksgiving was quiet — just John and me,
A much appreciated quiet reprieve
From traveling, company, work, meetings and more
Before December hit with activities galore!

First tryouts for Disney’s *Beauty and the Beast***
With 115 students trying out, at least!
David and I found meaningful spots for every one,
And sighed with relief when we were finally done.

Then off to Manhattan “Buddy” and I went
To help unpack the moving bins for John and Elizabeth,
Settling them into their larger condo
And assembling shelving and bunk beds for Mateo.

A very productive and satisfying weekend
Especially since the somewhat impatient Elena Lynn
Decided not to wait for her December 23rd C-section
And chose December 19 to surprise her Dad and Mom!

We flew back to NYC on December twenty one,
To meet Elena Lynn and have five days of fun
Celebrating Christmas with all of Elizabeth’s family
And sharing the joy of their brand new baby!

Then back to Ohio to celebrate again
With Lisa’s whole family, Lauren, Mike, Leo and Lynn.
Paul and Allison didn’t make it to Ohio this year
Their baby boy’s due date precluded their travel here.

That brings us up to 2026
Which we kicked off with our family ski trip!
The crew here for Christmas plus Mateo and John
All joined us in Beaver Creek for a week of skiing fun.

Conditions were not optimal —some runs were closed
John and I limited ourselves to bunny slopes.
But our kids found good skiing on many runs,
And their kids all progressed in lessons and had fun.

Then back to school, rehearsals, set building and design.
John to AAO calls and mentoring time.
Snow days created challenges for *Beauty and the Beast***
Delaying rehearsals and set supplies by a week.

Every actor had at least two costumes each!
Plus there were 45 tech crew members to teach.
With parental help joining students on weekend work sessions
And patiently answering millions of questions,

We managed to finish by opening night
And incredibly everything turned out all right!

John traveled to the west coast two weekends in a row
For committee meetings for the AAO***
One was for membership; one he chairs—that’s LEO****
Fortunately, he made it back in time to see my final show!
As soon as it was over we went off to see
The newest addition to our family:

Luca Franklin Stechschulte!
Born on the 25th of February.
Joining big sister Gemma and big brother Finn
Just looking at him makes me break into a grin!

Our timing proved perfect in every way,
As we went to school with Gemma for Grandparents Day!
We stayed with Jeri and Peter - lots of room in their 'inn"
Kara and Patrick even came to meet Luca & see Gemma & Finn!

It's a joy to spend time with our children's families.
They've all chosen great spouses who make them happy.
And getting to know grandchildren is truly great!
We feel very blessed that we now have eight!

Spring break took us back to Florida again
With all of John's and Lisa's families and with Lauren,
Spent time with Kris, Jan & Tom and niece Kelli's family, too.
Mateo's "extended family" which he found very cool!

Gasparilla Island's an idyllic getaway,
But the drive there and back—a disaster barely at bay.
So we rented a storage unit for all our beach supplies:
Towels, chairs, umbrellas, toys. Next year we plan to fly!

John attended the mid-year forum in Washington, DC.
With several residents that he's mentored for the Academy.
With the timing, heat, tight schedule, I opted to stay home.
We'd had a very busy winter, I was okay resting alone.

In May we tried to catch up with some of our nearby friends,
We've been so very busy, we're sad to have neglected them.
Managed to see several and make some long distance calls.
Know we still care even if we didn't reach you all.

June brought a new adventure: a river cruise in France,
With our daughters & their partners — our boys lost the chance
When both wives were having babies too young to leave behind,
They only lost a week of fun for the joy of a lifetime!

We started out in Paris took a train to Chalon-Sur-Saone
Traveled down that river and then continued on the Rhone.
Saw many historic sites and beautiful vineyards, too.
Learned a lot of medieval history and ate delicious food.

Our kids enjoyed the cruise, pleased with all the things to do,
And were happy to discover other young people onboard, too.
We shared lots of memories & laughter in the evening up on deck
Missed the boys & their wives. They'll choose where we go next.

John, Elizabeth, Mateo & Elena were here the first week of July.
Elena at 6 months, sits up well and has a lot to say.
Mateo spent 4 days at an impressive robotics camp,
Built a robot he can program and it runs like a champ!

We celebrated the 4th with a trip to the local parade,
Enjoyed late afternoon at Mark & Beth's pool even tho it rained.
It rained again for fireworks - by then it was too late,
We were cozy here at home and couldn't stay awake.

We're headed off to birthday week the last week of July,
As Christopher, Elizabeth & Zachary mark 1 more year gone by.
Our August plans include a new left hip for me
And better vision in both eyes with cataract surgeries.

Thank you for your patience with my Christmas cards always late
I just need to have life slow down some to keep you up to date.
We thank you for your friendship, wish you blessings every day.
May God protect all those you love and keep all of you safe.

Love,
Jodi & John Stechschulte.

jodisteck@gmail.com
john.stechschulte@gmail.com

*Kindergarten!
** JR version
*** American Academy of Ophthalmology
**** Lifelong Engaged Ophthalmologists